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Machine Learning Based Spectrum Allocation for THz UAV Communications

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ABSTRACT Terahertz links between unmanned aerial vehicles offer very wide bandwidth, but molecular absorption splits the band into frequency-dependent transmission windows, and mobility misaligns the narrow beams. The achievable capacity therefore depends on which frequency channels are activated and how the transmit power is shared among them. The existing threshold-search method MaxActive returns the best channel set within its search family but must repeat its search over thousands of channels at every geometry update. This paper investigates machine-learning alternatives that work from the same physical channel state. Eighteen supervised regressors from six model families predict the capacity that the search would deliver, and a dueling double deep Q-network, formulated as a single-step contextual bandit, learns the channel-selection decision itself. All methods are evaluated with data regenerated from a physics-consistent terahertz model under four mobility patterns, using leakage-safe nested cross-validation. A Gaussian process predicts the capacity most accurately, whereas single trees, plain boosting, and unregularized linear regression overshoot the physical bound. The learned policy attains at least 99.7% of the reference capacity at every evaluated geometry, but the policy is trained separately for each operating context, with the reference capacity in its reward. Once trained, both learned approaches lower the online decision cost by about two orders of magnitude or more and occupy only kilobytes of memory.

INDEX TERMS Beam misalignment, channel selection, contextual bandit, deep reinforcement learning, Gaussian process, machine learning, spectrum allocation, terahertz communications, unmanned aerial vehicles.

I. INTRODUCTION

TERAHERTZ (THz) frequencies (0.1–10 THz) offer contiguous bandwidths of tens to hundreds of gigahertz, which makes the band a candidate for sixth-generation (6G) wireless systems and, in particular, for high-capacity links between unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) such as drone swarms and aerial backhaul [1]–[3]. At the altitudes where drones operate, the water-vapor concentration is lower than at sea level, so THz links are more practical in the air than on the ground [4], [5]. THz propagation, however, differs from microwave and millimeter-wave propagation in ways that matter for system design. The free-space spreading loss grows with the square of both distance and frequency [6], and water-vapor molecules absorb energy at many discrete resonance lines, so the attenuation changes by orders of magnitude across the band. The usable spectrum consequently consists of transmission windows that narrow as the distance grows [6], [7]. The absorbed energy is re-radiated as molecular absorption noise, which makes the noise level depend on frequency and distance as well [6]. Highly directional antennas close the link budget, but narrow beams are easily misaligned when the aircraft move [8]. The capacity of a UAV-to-UAV THz link consequently depends jointly on distance, absorption, noise, antenna gain, beamwidth, and beam alignment, and the capacity can collapse by many orders of magnitude when the beams drift apart [9].

Spectrum allocation is thus a central design problem for such links. The band is divided into many narrow frequency

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channels, and for every link geometry the transmitter must decide which channels to activate and how to divide its fixed transmit power among them. Each additional active channel adds bandwidth but takes power away from the other channels. A channel near an absorption line contributes little capacity and much noise, whereas concentrating the power on too few channels wastes bandwidth. The best allocation changes whenever the distance or the beam alignment changes, so a mobile UAV link has to recompute the allocation continuously.

A. RELATED WORK

Most prior work addresses THz spectrum allocation with optimization-based methods, and a smaller but growing body of work replaces these methods with learned models.

Han *et al.* [7] exploited the distance-dependent transmission windows with a multi-wideband waveform and optimized the transmit power and the number of frames on each sub-window to maximize the communication distance under rate and power constraints. Shafie *et al.* [10] designed adaptive, unequal sub-band bandwidths for multiuser THz systems, which mitigates the variation of absorption loss across sub-bands and increases the throughput. Both works target terrestrial links and do not model aerial mobility. For aerial platforms, Saeed *et al.* [5] proposed the common flat band (CFB) scheme, which keeps the channels where both the path gain and the noise spectral density are flat, and analyzed the capacity of THz links for drones, aircraft, and satellites. Xu *et al.* [11] jointly optimized the UAV location, bandwidth, and power for UAV-to-ground links. Beam-oriented works such as LeTera [12] and LeBeam [8] adapt the beamwidth to in-flight mobility but assume a single THz channel and do not address channel selection. Saeed *et al.* [9] combined these directions for drone-to-drone links by jointly considering channel selection, water-filling (WF) or equal-power (EP) allocation, and beamwidth adjustment, and proposed the MaxActive channel-selection scheme. MaxActive with EP achieved a capacity close to that of the WF-based schemes while outperforming CFB and standard full-band selection under EP, and MaxActive is the reference solution adopted in the present paper. The main practical drawback of MaxActive is its computational cost [13]: the search re-evaluates the capacity over the whole band for many candidate channel sets, and the joint allocation loop must be repeated after every geometry change.

Machine learning (ML) has been used to replace costly resource-allocation algorithms with fast learned mappings. Sun *et al.* [14] showed that a neural network trained to imitate an iterative power-control algorithm reproduces the output of the algorithm at a small fraction of its run time, an approach known as learning to optimize. Deep reinforcement learning (DRL) has been applied widely to wireless resource management [15], for example as multi-agent deep Q-learning for dynamic power allocation [16]. For THz systems, Shafie *et al.* [17] trained a deep network without labels to approximate a sub-band allocation; as noted in [13], such unsupervised schemes are sensitive to training and can occasionally violate hard power or bandwidth constraints. Hu and Han [18] recently combined graph neural networks with DRL to allocate power and antenna sub-arrays in dynamic THz UAV networks, with resource efficiency rather than per-link channel selection as the objective. Surveys of ML for THz communications are given in [19]. The work closest to the present paper is that of Elçik *et al.* [13], who formulated THz drone-to-drone channel selection as a contextual bandit solved by a dueling double deep Q-network (D3QN). The D3QN policy matched the MaxActive capacity with a much lower operation count, but the policy requires a separately trained model for every distance–gain pair and was tested on a narrower band (0.5–1 THz) with a single learning method.

B. RESEARCH GAP AND CONTRIBUTIONS

Two questions remain open. The first is whether a deep reinforcement learning policy is necessary, or whether simpler supervised models trained on the same physical channel state can predict the outcome of the spectrum-allocation search. The second is what such alternatives cost in accuracy, physical feasibility, run time, memory, and training effort, when validated with a protocol that is credible for the small datasets a physics simulator produces. The present paper addresses both questions for the MaxActive spectrum allocation problem of [9], with the following contributions.

1) A physics-consistent reproduction of the MaxActive capacity under WF and EP allocation for four UAV mobility patterns, including mobility over elevation and measured windy-hover acceleration traces. All capacity values are regenerated from the reference simulation code rather than digitized from published figures, and the values serve as a reusable ground truth for learning.
2) A systematic benchmark of eighteen supervised regressors from six model families that predict the capacity of the spectrum-allocation search from thirteen physical channel features. The evaluation uses leakage-safe nested cross-validation and reports how often each model exceeds the physical capacity bound.
3) A D3QN channel-selection policy that operates on the same individual channels as MaxActive. The policy is contrasted with the regressors as an example of learning the allocation decision rather than the value of the decision, and the per-context training that the policy requires is stated explicitly.
4) A convergence and complexity analysis that combines asymptotic cost with measured execution time and memory footprint. The analysis separates model inference from the feature extraction that precedes inference, so the reported speed-ups compare like with like.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section II presents the THz UAV channel model, the spectrum allocation problem, and the two existing solutions, MaxActive and the D3QN policy. Section III describes the alternative ML solutions, Section IV gives the simulation setup and the results, Section V analyzes convergence and complexity, and Section VI concludes the paper.

II. SYSTEM MODEL AND BACKGROUND

A. THz UAV CHANNEL MODEL

We consider a link between a transmitting (Tx) and a receiving (Rx) UAV, as in [9]. At time t the two UAVs are at the three-dimensional positions $\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{Tx}}(t)$ and $\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{Rx}}(t)$, separated by the distance $d = \|\mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{Rx}}(t) - \mathbf{p}_{\mathrm{Tx}}(t)\|$, and the time index is dropped below when no confusion arises. Either UAV may move. In the scenarios studied here, the Tx hovers and the Rx moves, except in the real-trace scenario, where both UAVs move. The THz band $[f_{\min}, f_{\max}]$ is divided into a set $\mathcal{F}$ of narrowband channels. Channel $i \in \mathcal{F}$ has center frequency f_i and width Δf_i, which equals the spectral resolution of the atmospheric data. A spectrum allocation activates a subset $\Omega \subseteq \mathcal{F}$ and assigns a transmit power $P_i \geq 0$ to each active channel.

The path loss of channel i is the product of a spreading loss and an absorption loss [6]. The spreading (free-space) loss is the Friis term, which in decibels, with d in meters and f_i in megahertz, reads

$$L_{\mathrm{spr},i}(d) = 20\log_{10} d + 20\log_{10} f_i - 27.55. \tag{1}$$

The absorption loss follows from the Beer–Lambert law, under which the fraction of power that passes through a path of length d is the transmittance

$$\tau_i(d) = e^{-k_i d}, \tag{2}$$

where k_i is the molecular absorption coefficient of the atmosphere at frequency f_i. We obtain k_i from transmittance values computed by the line-by-line radiative transfer model (LBLRTM) [20] for the UAV altitude, as in [9]. The absorption loss is $L_{\mathrm{abs},i}(d) = 10\log_{10}\big(1/\tau_i(d)\big) = 10\,k_i d \log_{10} e$ dB, and the total path loss in linear scale is

$$A_i(d) = 10^{\,[L_{\mathrm{spr},i}(d) + L_{\mathrm{abs},i}(d)]/10}. \tag{3}$$

Because k_i varies by orders of magnitude between neighboring channels, the path loss A_i is highly frequency selective, and because $L_{\mathrm{abs},i}$ grows linearly with d, the transmission windows narrow as the UAVs move apart. The molecules that absorb THz energy also re-emit part of the energy as molecular absorption noise. With the path emissivity $1 - \tau_i(d)$, the noise power in channel i is [6]

$$P_{N,i}(d) = k_B\, T_0 \left(1 - \tau_i(d)\right) \Delta f_i, \tag{4}$$

where k_B is the Boltzmann constant and T_0 is the reference temperature, so the noise is strongest exactly where the absorption is strongest.

Both UAVs use the three-dimensional spherical-lobe (sectored) antenna model of [9], with the same beamwidth ψ (in radians) in elevation and azimuth. The antenna of node $a \in \{\mathrm{Tx}, \mathrm{Rx}\}$ has the gain

$$G_a = \begin{cases} 4\pi/\psi^2, & |\Delta\theta_a| \leq \psi/2 \text{ and } |\Delta\phi_a| \leq \psi/2, \\ \rho, & \text{otherwise}, \end{cases} \tag{5}$$

where $\Delta\theta_a$ and $\Delta\phi_a$ are the azimuth and elevation (zenith) angles between the antenna boresight and the instantaneous line of sight to the other UAV, and $\rho \ll 1$ is the side-lobe level. When the boresight points to the zenith or the nadir, the azimuth is undefined and only the elevation condition is applied. The boresights are fixed by the initial geometry. As the UAVs move, the line of sight rotates away from the boresights, and once the line of sight leaves the main lobe, the gain drops from $4\pi/\psi^2$ to ρ, a condition referred to as beam misalignment. Beamwidth adjustment widens the beam to keep the link in the main lobe, at the price of a lower main-lobe gain $4\pi/\psi^2$. The total link gain is $G = G_{\mathrm{Tx}} G_{\mathrm{Rx}}$.

With power P_i on channel i, the signal-to-noise ratio (SNR) of the channel is

$$\gamma_i = \frac{P_i\, G}{A_i(d)\, P_{N,i}(d)}. \tag{6}$$

The SNR combines all the physical effects above: distance and frequency through A_i, the atmosphere through A_i and $P_{N,i}$, and geometry and beam alignment through G. Treating each channel as an additive white Gaussian noise channel, the link capacity of an allocation $(\Omega, \{P_i\})$ is the Shannon sum

$$C(\Omega, \{P_i\}) = \sum_{i \in \Omega} \Delta f_i\, \log_2(1 + \gamma_i)\,. \tag{7}$$

Two power-allocation policies are considered. Under EP, the total transmit power P_T is split evenly across the active channels,

$$P_i = P_T/|\Omega|, \qquad i \in \Omega. \tag{8}$$

Under WF, which maximizes (7) for a fixed set Ω [21],

$$P_i = \max\big(0,\ \mu - A_i P_{N,i}/G\big), \qquad i \in \Omega, \tag{9}$$

where the water level μ is chosen so that $\sum_{i\in\Omega} P_i = P_T$. WF gives more power to channels with low attenuation and noise and switches off channels whose effective noise $A_i P_{N,i}/G$ lies above the water level, whereas EP is simpler to implement because EP needs no per-channel power control.

B. PROBLEM FORMULATION

Following [9], the spectrum allocation problem at time t is to choose the active channel set, the power allocation, and the beamwidth that maximize the link capacity:

$$\max_{\Omega\subseteq\mathcal{F},\,\{P_i\},\,\psi} \quad C(\Omega, \{P_i\}) \tag{10a}$$

$$\text{s.t.} \quad \textstyle\sum_{i\in\Omega} P_i \leq P_T, \tag{10b}$$

$$P_i \geq 0,\ i \in \Omega; \qquad P_i = 0,\ i \notin \Omega, \tag{10c}$$

$$\psi_0 \leq \psi \leq \psi_{\max}, \tag{10d}$$

where ψ_0 is the nominal beamwidth and $\psi_{\max}$ the widest admissible one. The capacity depends on ψ through the gain

G in (6). The problem is combinatorial in Ω, which has $2^{|\mathcal{F}|}$ candidate subsets with $|\mathcal{F}|$ in the thousands in the THz band. The problem is also coupled, because the best channels depend on the powers and vice versa, so an exhaustive search is infeasible [9]. Since (10) is solved for every geometry, the solution must be recomputed as the UAVs move.

Reference [9] decomposes (10) into two stages. In the first stage, beamwidth adjustment, ψ is chosen so that the link stays in the main lobe with the largest gain. In the second stage, channel selection and power allocation, a channel-selection rule and the power allocation (8) or (9) are iterated for the resulting gain until the channel set they produce no longer changes. The spectrum-allocation decision studied in this paper is the output of the second stage, namely the set Ω and the capacity C that the set delivers.

C. EXISTING SOLUTION: MAXACTIVE

MaxActive [9] solves the second stage by a threshold search on the SNR. The channels are ranked by SNR, and an SNR threshold is lowered from the largest SNR in decrements Δs. At each of the Q threshold levels, the candidate set Ω_j contains the channels whose SNR exceeds the threshold; the power allocation is applied to Ω_j, and the capacity (7) of the candidate set is evaluated. MaxActive returns the candidate set with the largest capacity. Because the candidates are SNR-ordered prefixes $\Omega_1 \subset \Omega_2 \subset \cdots$, the search examines at most $|\mathcal{F}|$ sets rather than $2^{|\mathcal{F}|}$. Each evaluation sums up to $|\mathcal{F}|$ terms, which gives a per-update cost of $O(Q\,|\mathcal{F}|)$, and [9] gives a detailed worst-case operation count. In the joint scheme, MaxActive and the power allocation run in alternation until their channel sets agree. Reference [9] showed that MaxActive with EP closely approaches the WF capacity and is the most practical of the schemes considered there.

The search thus returns the best member of the family of SNR-ordered nested subsets for the given channel state and power allocation. The optimality holds only within the adopted threshold-search family: subsets that are not SNR-ordered prefixes are never examined, so global optimality over all $2^{|\mathcal{F}|}$ subsets is not claimed in general. Under EP with (near-)equal channel widths, every selected channel receives the same power, and the capacity-maximizing subset of any given size consists of the highest-SNR channels. In that case, restricting the search to SNR-ordered prefixes loses nothing, provided that the search examines every prefix length. In addition, selection and power allocation are optimized alternately rather than jointly, so MaxActive is optimal conditioned on the power allocation supplied to the search, not for the joint selection-and-power problem (10). In this restricted sense, and within the LBLRTM channel model and the spherical-lobe antenna model, MaxActive serves as the learning target and the reference throughout this paper. The cost of MaxActive motivates learning: the threshold search re-evaluates the capacity over every channel of a wide band at every geometry update, on a processor that also flies the aircraft.

D. EXISTING LEARNING-BASED SOLUTION: D3QN CHANNEL SELECTION

Elçik *et al.* [13] replaced the threshold search by a learned policy. In deep Q-learning [22], a neural network with weights $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ approximates the action-value function $Q(\mathbf{s}, a)$, which is the expected return of action a in state $\mathbf{s}$, and the agent acts greedily, $a^\star = \arg\max_a Q(\mathbf{s}, a; \boldsymbol{\theta})$. Two refinements give the D3QN. The double-DQN target [23]

$$y = r + \beta\, Q\big(\mathbf{s}', \arg\max_{a'} Q(\mathbf{s}', a'; \boldsymbol{\theta}); \boldsymbol{\theta}^-\big) \tag{11}$$

uses the online weights $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ to choose the next action and a separate target network $\boldsymbol{\theta}^-$ to evaluate the chosen action, which reduces overestimation; here r is the reward, $\mathbf{s}'$ the next state, and β the discount factor. The dueling architecture [24] splits the network into a state-value stream $V(\mathbf{s})$ and an advantage stream $A(\mathbf{s}, a)$ and combines the two streams as

$$Q(\mathbf{s}, a) = V(\mathbf{s}) + \Big(A(\mathbf{s}, a) - \frac{1}{|\mathcal{A}|}\sum_{a' \in \mathcal{A}} A(\mathbf{s}, a')\Big), \tag{12}$$

where $\mathcal{A}$ is the action set. Subtracting the mean advantage makes the decomposition identifiable.

In [13], the state collects the path loss and the noise power of every channel. An action a selects a number of channels, and that many highest-SNR channels are activated with EP. The reward is a logarithmic transform of the achieved capacity. Because the selected channels do not change the next channel state, the problem was cast as a contextual bandit [25], and one network is pre-trained for each pair of distance and total gain. Over 0.5–1 THz, the learned policy matched the MaxActive capacity with about 10^4 times fewer operations. The present paper re-implements the policy over the full 0.75–4.4 THz band of [9] and compares the policy with supervised alternatives.

III. ALTERNATIVE MACHINE LEARNING SOLUTIONS

A. TWO WAYS TO LEARN THE SPECTRUM ALLOCATION

All learned models in this work use the same physical channel state as MaxActive. For each operating context, defined by a UAV geometry and the resulting gain G, beamwidth ψ, and distance d, the channel state consists of the per-channel path losses $\{A_i\}$ and noise powers $\{P_{N,i}\}$. Two learning targets are possible. A capacity regressor learns the value of the spectrum-allocation decision by mapping a compact feature vector $\mathbf{x}$ of the channel state to an estimate $\hat{C}$ of the capacity that MaxActive would achieve, in the spirit of [14]. A selection policy learns the decision itself by mapping the channel state to a set of active channels, whose capacity is then evaluated with the physical model (6)–(7). Because a regressor returns a number rather than a channel set, the regressor can predict a capacity that no feasible allocation reaches, whereas a policy returns an allocation

that can be transmitted, and the capacity reported for the policy is the capacity that the allocation actually delivers.

Because MaxActive returns the best capacity within its search family, MaxActive upper-bounds any model trained to imitate the search. When regressor outputs are plotted against the reference, we display

$$\hat{C}_{\text{clip}} = \min\big(\hat{C},\, C_{\text{MaxActive}}\big). \tag{13}$$

The clip (13) requires $C_{\text{MaxActive}}$, which is exactly the quantity a deployed regressor does not have; if the reference were available online, no learned model would be needed. The clip is used only for offline visualization and is not part of the online prediction path. At deployment, the regressor emits $\hat{C}$ and the policy emits a channel set, with no access to the reference. Every reported error is computed from raw, unclipped predictions, and the ceiling violations that the clip would hide are reported explicitly.

B. PHYSICAL FEATURE VECTOR AND LEARNING TARGET

The regressors do not see the $|\mathcal{F}|$ individual channels. Instead, each operating context is summarized by a 13-dimensional feature vector built from quantities of the channel model. The band is divided into $K = 20$ equal-width sub-bands, and for each sub-band k we compute the mean total path loss $\bar{L}_k$ (in decibels), the mean absorption-noise power $\bar{P}_{N,k}$ from (4), and the received-power indicator $\Pi_k = \log_{10}\big(P_T\, G \,/\, 10^{\bar{L}_k/10}\big)$, which is the numerator of the SNR (6) under full power, expressed in $\log_{10}$ watts. The features fall into three groups. The geometry and antenna features are $\log_{10}(d+1)$ and its square, the normalized total gain $G_{\text{dB}}/60$ and its square, and the normalized beamwidth $\psi/360^\circ$; together they capture the distance dependence of (1) and the alignment state of (5). The channel-quality features are the mean and the standard deviation over sub-bands of Π_k and of $\log_{10}\bar{P}_{N,k}$, the normalized mean path loss $\overline{L}/200$, and the fraction of sub-bands that contain channels. The means describe the strength of the link, and the standard deviations describe the frequency selectivity of the link, which governs how many channels are worth activating. The two context labels are a mobility-scenario index and a power-allocation flag; the allocation flag is constant within each training set, because WF and EP are learned as separate targets.

The learning target is the base-10 logarithm of the MaxActive capacity in gigabits per second, $y = \log_{10}(C_{\text{MaxActive}}/1\ \text{Gbps})$, computed separately for WF and EP. The logarithm is essential, because across the scenarios the capacity spans about nine orders of magnitude, and on the logarithmic scale the capacity curve is smooth. For the models that are sensitive to feature scale, each feature is standardized to zero mean and unit variance using statistics of the training data only.

C. SUPERVISED CAPACITY REGRESSORS

Each regressor learns a mapping $f(\mathbf{x}) \approx y$ from labeled examples $\{(\mathbf{x}_n, y_n)\}$ generated by the reference model, using the standard training objective of the regressor. To avoid committing to one hypothesis class in advance, we evaluate eighteen regressors in six families [26], [27], which differ in inductive bias and computational character.

The linear and regularized family (ordinary least squares, LinearReg; Ridge; Lasso; ElasticNet; BayesianRidge) assumes that y is affine in $\mathbf{x}$. In the log domain, the capacity is approximately affine in log-distance and gain, so linear models are natural baselines, and the ℓ_2, ℓ_1, elastic-net, and evidence-based variants separate the bias of the affine hypothesis from the bias of the penalty. Training costs $O(nd^2)$ for n samples and d features, and a prediction is a d-term dot product. The robust linear model, Huber regression, uses a loss that is quadratic for small residuals and linear for large ones, which tests the sensitivity to the extreme dynamic range.

The kernel and probabilistic family (support vector regression with a radial basis function kernel, SVR-RBF; kernel ridge regression, KernelRidge; and a Gaussian process, GaussProc) models smooth nonlinear functions through a kernel that measures the similarity of two operating contexts. The Gaussian process [28] uses a squared-exponential kernel plus a white-noise term, returns the posterior mean, and sets its kernel hyperparameters by maximizing the marginal likelihood. Kernel models suit a smooth capacity surface, but their training cost grows as $O(n^2)$ to $O(n^3)$ with the number of samples.

The instance-based learner, k-nearest neighbors (k-NN), predicts the capacity as an average over the most similar training contexts; the learner interpolates locally and needs no training, but every prediction scans the stored data. The neural family is represented by a multilayer perceptron (MLP), a flexible function approximator trained by gradient descent on the squared error. The tree ensembles (RandomForest, ExtraTrees, Bagging, AdaBoost, gradient boosting, GradBoost, and XGBoost [27]), together with a single DecisionTree as an unregularized contrast, partition the feature space into regions with a constant prediction in each region. Tree ensembles are strong learners for tabular data, but a piecewise-constant function cannot extrapolate a curve that spans many decades.

A histogram-based gradient-boosting regressor was also implemented and then discarded, because the method is designed for large binned datasets and gives a negative cross-validated R^2 on 33 samples. Since models within a family behave alike here while the families differ by orders of magnitude in error, adding more members of an existing family is unlikely to change the ranking, whereas omitting a family could.

The regressor output $\hat{C}$ estimates the capacity that the spectrum-allocation search would deliver at the current geometry and can serve, for example, in link-budget and rate

decisions. A regressor does not return the channel set Ω, so where the set itself is needed, the D3QN policy described next must be used. Because a regressor is not tied to a feasible allocation, nothing prevents $\hat{C}$ from exceeding the physical bound, and the frequency of such violations is a first-class evaluation criterion.

D. D3QN CHANNEL-SELECTION POLICY

The decision branch re-implements the D3QN of [13] at the same individual-channel granularity as MaxActive. The channels are ranked by $1/(A_i P_{N,i})$, which is the SNR order (6) at a common power level, and the state stacks the log path loss and the log noise power of the N best-ranked channels,

$$\mathbf{s} = \big[\log_{10} A_{(1)}, \ldots, \log_{10} A_{(N)}, \log_{10} P_{N,(1)}, \ldots, \log_{10} P_{N,(N)}\big], \tag{14}$$

where the subscript (m) denotes the mth-ranked channel. An action $a \in \mathcal{A}$ selects a number of channels $N_{\text{sel}}(a)$, and the N_{sel} highest-ranked channels are activated with EP (8). The action space thus contains only SNR-ordered prefixes, the same family that MaxActive searches, and the resulting allocation is evaluated with the physical model (6)–(7), which gives the true capacity C of the decision. Following [13], the reward is

$$r = \ln\big((C_{\max} - C_{\min}) + 1\big) - \ln\big((C_{\max} - C) + 1\big), \tag{15}$$

where all capacities are in bit/s. In the implementation, as in [13], $C_{\max}$ is the MaxActive-EP capacity of the current context, obtained by searching the same SNR-ordered prefixes, and $C_{\min} = 0$, so the reward reduces to $r = \ln(C_{\max} + 1) - \ln(C_{\max} - C + 1)$. The reward is zero for $C = 0$ and reaches its maximum $\ln(C_{\max} + 1)$ when the policy matches the reference, and the logarithms compress the very large capacity range of a THz link. Because $C_{\max}$ enters the reward, training the policy for a context requires the reference capacity of that context; only the trained policy, not its training, is independent of the search.

The action values are produced by the dueling decomposition (12) from a small fully connected trunk. Training alternates ϵ-greedy exploration, which evaluates the capacity of each explored action with the physical model, with gradient steps that regress $Q(\mathbf{s}, a)$ onto the observed reward under a smooth-ℓ_1 loss, using minibatches drawn from a replay memory. After training, the returned decision is

$$a_{\text{out}} = \arg \max_{a \in \{a^\star\} \cup \mathcal{A}_{\text{exp}}} C(a), \qquad a^\star = \arg\max_a Q(\mathbf{s}, a), \tag{16}$$

where $\mathcal{A}_{\text{exp}}$ is the set of actions explored during training and $C(a)$ are their evaluated capacities. The greedy action of the trained network is thus kept unless an action already evaluated during training delivered a higher capacity. The fallback is part of the implementation of the policy and of every D3QN result reported here.

For a given geometry, the channel state $\mathbf{s}$ is fixed: the agent takes one action, receives one reward, and the episode ends. The current selection does not change the channel state at the next geometry, which is set by the trajectory and the physics. With no state transition to influence, the horizon is one and the discount β in (11) is zero, so the double-DQN target reduces to the immediate reward, $y = r$, and $Q(\mathbf{s}, a)$ estimates the reward of action a. The problem is a contextual $|\mathcal{A}|$-armed bandit [25] rather than sequential reinforcement learning, and the mechanisms that make deep reinforcement learning fragile, namely bootstrapping bias, moving targets, and delayed rewards, are absent. Because the target is the immediate reward, the separate target network of (11) is neither needed nor used. We keep the dueling architecture and the D3QN name for fidelity to [13], [24] but claim no sequential decision-making.

The policy outputs a channel set that can be transmitted. The capacity of the set is that of a feasible SNR-ordered prefix with equal power, so the capacity cannot exceed that of the best such prefix, which is the set MaxActive-EP searches for. The policy can therefore at best match the reference and cannot improve on the reference. Agreement with MaxActive must also be read in light of the training procedure: policy training uses the reference capacity $C_{\max}$ in the reward, and by (16) the reported decision is the best of the greedy action and the actions evaluated during training, so the agreement reflects the learned network together with the exploration performed while training the network. The implementation does not record which of the two sources produced the returned action.

As in [13], the policy is trained per operating context, with one lightweight network for each pair of distance and gain. A previously unseen geometry is therefore not covered by an already-trained network, and obtaining a policy for the new geometry requires a separate training run, which itself needs the reference capacity of that geometry. The training run is short in absolute terms, but the run is an offline cost that exceeds the cost of a single MaxActive search. The present D3QN branch suits a trajectory envelope that can be enumerated and trained for in advance and pays off only when a trained context recurs; the branch does not suit an arbitrary geometry met in flight. The supervised branch does not share the restriction, because one fitted regressor maps the features of any geometry inside the trained envelope to a capacity estimate. Two routes would lift the restriction, and both are left to future work: conditioning a single network on the geometry descriptors that the regressors already use, or training a bank of policies offline and selecting among the policies by nearest context at run time.

IV. PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS

A. SIMULATION PARAMETERS AND DATA GENERATION

The physical layer is reproduced in Python from the MATLAB simulation code of [9], which also supplies the LBLRTM transmittance files, the antenna model, the initial coordinates and velocities, and the trajectory generators. The LBLRTM files are computed for a horizontal path at 100 m altitude and resolve the band at the ranges

TABLE 1. Simulation Parameters

Parameter	Value
THz band $[f_{\min}, f_{\max}]$	0.75–4.4 THz
Active channels per context $\lvert\mathcal{F}\rvert$	11 699 ($\approx$11 700)
Channel width Δf_i	$\approx$ 0.312 GHz (LBLRTM resolution)
Atmospheric data	LBLRTM, horizontal path, 100 m altitude
LBLRTM ranges	$1, 11, \ldots, 101$ m (Beer–Lambert rescaling)
Reference temperature T_0	296 K
Total transmit power P_T	24 dBm
Antenna model	spherical lobe, symmetric beams
Nominal beamwidth ψ_0 (Tx, Rx)	10°
Main-lobe link gain at ψ_0	$\approx$ 52.3 dB
Side-lobe level ρ (Tx, Rx)	0.1
Beamwidth search	$[\psi_0, 360^\circ]$: 15-point grid, then 2° steps
Power allocation	EP (8) or WF (9)
Selection/allocation loop	alternate until the sets agree (max. 30 iterations)
Tx initial position	$(0, 10, 100)$ m
Rx initial position (scenarios 1, 2, 4)	$(0, 11, 100)$ m ($d = 1$ m)

$\{1, 11, \ldots, 101\}$ m. For any other range, the transmittance of the nearest file is rescaled to the exact distance by the Beer–Lambert law (2). All capacities used in this paper are regenerated by the reference code. No value is read off a published figure, and where a regenerated value differs from a figure of [9], the regenerated value is kept. The transmit power of 24 dBm is taken from the reference simulation code, and the main parameters are listed in Table 1.

The MaxActive threshold sweep is implemented as an equivalent sweep over the number of retained SNR-ranked channels, with a coarse grid followed by a unit-step refinement around the best value. The power allocation and MaxActive are alternated until the active set is stable. In the scenarios with beamwidth adjustment, the common Tx/Rx beamwidth is searched over $[\psi_0, 360^\circ]$ before each selection, maximizing the EP capacity over the full band.

Four mobility patterns are generated, the last three of which are misaligned. Each pattern is evaluated with WF and EP, the misaligned patterns are evaluated with and without beamwidth adjustment, and the antenna boresights are fixed by the first position of each trajectory.

1) In the aligned scenario, the Rx recedes along the y-axis at 10 m/s for 11 steps, giving $d = 1, 11, \ldots, 101$ m with the beams aligned throughout.
2) In the misaligned scenario with diagonal mobility, the Rx recedes with velocity $(5\sqrt{2}, 5\sqrt{2}, 0)$ m/s, so the fixed 10° beams progressively misalign over 11 steps.
3) In the misaligned scenario with mobility over elevation, the Rx moves on a hemisphere of radius 20 m around the Tx, with the elevation (zenith) angle ϕ swept from 0° to 180° in 10° steps (19 points). The distance is constant, so the capacity changes only through misalignment.
4) In the misaligned scenario with real mobility traces, the Tx and Rx positions are integrated from measured windy-hover acceleration traces (the drone traces of [8], as supplied with the reference code), with an initial diagonal drift of the Rx. The scenario has 11 points over 0–5 s, and the distance varies between 1.0 and 52.9 m.

For the supervised study, one sample is built per scenario–geometry pair. The main dataset combines the aligned scenario and the diagonal scenario with and without adjustment, giving $3 \times 11 = 33$ samples. A separate mobility dataset contains the elevation (2×19) and real-trace (2×11) points, 60 samples in total, and is built identically. Each sample carries the 13 features described above and the targets y for WF and EP. The sample count is set by the reference model rather than by a sampling choice, because the LBLRTM files resolve the straight-line geometry at eleven ranges and every extra sample costs a full physics evaluation. Three properties make the small-sample regime workable. The target is a deterministic, noiseless function of the features, so n controls only the resolution of the input space and not the variance of the labels. The input space is low dimensional and physically smooth, with the capacity varying monotonically in distance and misalignment. Finally, the evaluation protocol is matched to the regime. Generating more data is embarrassingly parallel and linear in the number of operating points, at roughly 95 ms per sample, so denser range grids, more beamwidths, or more links would raise n from tens to 10^4–10^6 at a cost of CPU-hours. The present models are validated as interpolators within the envelope of geometries they were trained on, with no claim of extrapolation beyond the envelope.

Thirty-three samples cannot support a single train/test split for ranking eighteen models, so all regression metrics reported for the main dataset use nested cross-validation (CV). On the mobility dataset, the models are tuned by the same inner grid search and then fitted on all 60 samples, so the errors reported for the mobility dataset are in-sample. An outer repeated k-fold loop (5 folds $\times$ 3 repeats $=$ 15 folds) estimates generalization. On each outer training partition only, an inner 3-fold grid search tunes the hyperparameters, and the feature standardization sits inside the same pipeline, so no information leaks from the test fold. The metrics are the root-mean-square error (RMSE) and the coefficient of determination R^2 on the log target, and the median relative error of the capacity in linear Gbps, which avoids the inflation of the mean absolute percentage error at the very small far-distance capacities. The hyperparameter grids are listed in Table 2. The curves plotted in the figures come from each model refit on all samples, which is the estimator one would deploy, clipped at the ceiling (13) for display and drawn with monotone piecewise-cubic (PCHIP) interpolation

in log space, with markers at the computed points. The metrics come from raw out-of-fold predictions.

The D3QN policy uses the top $N = 500$ channels in the state (a 1000-dimensional input) and 600 actions. The first 50 actions select 1 to 50 channels individually, and the remaining 550 actions are spaced evenly up to the full channel count. The dueling network maps $1000 \to 16 \to 8$ to a value head and a 600-way advantage head and is trained for 20 epochs of 80 ϵ-greedy actions (Adam, learning rate 10^{-3}, weight decay 10^{-4}), with one network per pair of distance and gain. One gradient step on a replay minibatch of 64 is taken per epoch, i.e., 20 steps per context, while 1600 actions are evaluated, and the returned decision follows (16). The reference for the policy is MaxActive-EP over the same SNR-ranked channels. Since WF and EP give nearly equal capacities, the comparison with MaxActive-EP also tracks the WF reference.

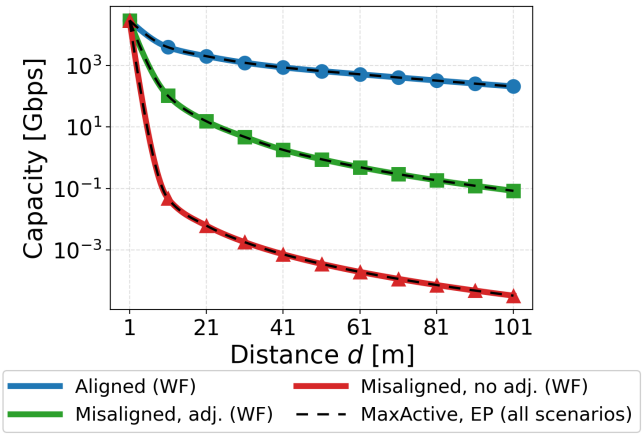


FIGURE 1. MaxActive reference capacity versus distance for the aligned link and for diagonal mobility with and without beamwidth adjustment, under WF (thick, solid) and EP (thin, dashed) allocation. The three scenarios occupy disjoint decades of the logarithmic axis, and WF and EP nearly coincide. Curves are PCHIP-smoothed, with markers at the computed distances.

B. RESULTS

Table 3 and Fig. 1 give the MaxActive capacity for the aligned and diagonal scenarios. The ordering aligned $>$ adjusted $>$ non-adjusted holds at every distance, and the three scenarios together span about nine decades. In the aligned case the capacity decays smoothly with distance, because both the spreading loss (1) and the absorption loss grow with d while the gain stays at its main-lobe value. Under diagonal mobility without adjustment, the line of sight leaves the 10° main lobe after the first step. The link then operates on the side lobes, where the gain falls from about 52 dB to ρ^2 (-20 dB), and the capacity drops by five to seven orders of magnitude relative to the aligned link. Beamwidth adjustment keeps the link in a wider main lobe and recovers more than three of the lost decades. WF and EP give nearly the same capacity in every scenario, because the channels that MaxActive selects at THz frequencies already have comparable and high SNR, so water filling adds little over equal power. The result confirms the observation of [9] that MaxActive with EP approaches the WF capacity.

Fig. 2 overlays one representative of each regressor family, together with the D3QN policy, on the MaxActive curves of the aligned and diagonal scenarios, and Fig. 3 does the same for the elevation and real-trace scenarios. In the elevation scenario without adjustment, the capacity stays high while the Rx is inside the half-power beam and then drops to a side-lobe plateau once ϕ leaves the beam. With adjustment, the beam widens and the capacity declines gradually instead. In the real traces, the diagonal drift produces a sharp collapse that the measured accelerations modulate with jitter, and because the trajectory begins at the reference initial distance of 1 m, the curve starts from a high capacity. In both figures, the kernel and instance-based representatives follow the reference closely, the linear representatives lag behind the reference, and the D3QN lies on the MaxActive curve throughout.

Table 4 gives the nested cross-validated metrics for the EP target, ranked by RMSE. The WF target was cross-validated in the same way, and the two targets agree to within 0.055 RMSE for every one of the eighteen models and to within 0.021 for all but the single decision tree, as the near-equality of the WF and EP capacities implies; only the EP column is tabulated.

The smooth nonparametric and kernel models perform best. The Gaussian process leads by a wide margin ($R^2 = 0.99$, median relative error $\approx 1.9\%$), followed by ExtraTrees, SVR-RBF, MLP, and k-NN. The leading models assume the smoothness that the physical capacity surface exhibits, so they interpolate MaxActive closely and generalize across folds. The regularized linear models, in contrast, are stable but biased: Ridge, Lasso, ElasticNet, and BayesianRidge hold $R^2 \approx 0.97$ with small variance, yet their $\approx 45\%$ median relative error reveals a systematic offset, because a model that is affine in the features cannot capture the curvature of a capacity that decays over nine decades.

Cross-validation also exposes failures that a single split hides. On a single 75/25 split, Huber regression is second only to the Gaussian process (RMSE 0.183), but under CV the Huber model falls to $R^2 = 0.93 \pm 0.10$. Ordinary least squares looks acceptable on the same split ($R^2 = 0.991$) but is far worse under CV ($R^2 = -7.98 \pm 31$), dominated by unlucky folds. Huber regression and ordinary least squares, together with the single decision tree and gradient boosting, are the failing methods. On 33 points a single split cannot be trusted, and the nested-CV mean $\pm$ std is the basis for the ranking.

The two ceiling-violation columns quantify how far the raw predictions exceed the reference ceiling. The excess is what the display clip (13) conceals and is the error a deployed regressor would actually commit, since a deployed regressor has no ceiling to clip against. Every regressor

TABLE 2. Learning Settings: Inner-CV Hyperparameter Grids of the Regressors and D3QN Configuration

Family	Model	Inner-CV grid (3-fold) or fitting rule
Linear/regularized	LinearReg	none (ordinary least squares)
	Ridge	$\alpha \in \{0.01, 0.1, 1, 10, 100\}$
	Lasso	$\alpha \in \{10^{-3}, 10^{-2}, 10^{-1}, 1\}$
	ElasticNet	$\alpha \in \{10^{-3}, 10^{-2}, 10^{-1}, 1\}$; ℓ_1 ratio $\in \{0.2, 0.5, 0.8\}$
	BayesianRidge	none (evidence maximization)
Robust	Huber	$\epsilon \in \{1.2, 1.35, 1.5\}$; $\alpha \in \{10^{-4}, 10^{-3}, 10^{-2}\}$
Kernel/probabilistic	SVR-RBF	$C \in \{1, 10, 100\}$; $\gamma \in \{\text{scale}, 0.1, 1\}$; $\epsilon \in \{0.01, 0.1\}$
	KernelRidge (RBF)	$\alpha \in \{0.01, 0.1, 1\}$; $\gamma \in \{0.1, 1, 10\}$
	GaussProc	constant $\times$ squared-exponential $+$ white-noise kernel; marginal-likelihood fit
Instance-based	k-NN	$k \in \{2, 3, 5\}$; uniform or distance weights
Neural	MLP	hidden layers $(64, 32)$ or $(128, 64)$; $\alpha \in \{10^{-4}, 10^{-3}, 10^{-2}\}$; early stopping
Trees	DecisionTree	depth $\in \{2, 3, 5, \text{none}\}$; minimum split $\in \{2, 4, 8\}$
	RandomForest, ExtraTrees	trees $\in \{100, 200\}$; depth $\in \{\text{none}, 5, 10\}$
	AdaBoost	estimators $\in \{50, 100\}$; learning rate $\in \{0.05, 0.1, 0.5\}$
	Bagging	estimators $\in \{50, 100\}$
	GradBoost, XGBoost	trees $\in \{100, 200\}$; depth $\in \{3, 5\}$; learning rate $\in \{0.05, 0.1\}$
D3QN	State	log path loss and log noise of the top $N = 500$ SNR-ranked channels (1000 inputs)
	Actions	600: $N_{\text{sel}} = 1, \ldots, 50$ individually, then 550 values evenly spaced up to $\lvert\mathcal{F}\rvert$
	Network	$1000 \to 16 \to 8$ (ReLU) $\to$ value head (1) and advantage head (600)
	Training	20 epochs $\times$ 80 ϵ-greedy actions, ϵ: $1.0 \to 0.02$ (linear); one replay minibatch (64) per epoch
	Optimizer	Adam, learning rate 10^{-3}, weight decay 10^{-4}; smooth-ℓ_1 loss; gradient-norm clip 1.0
	Reward / output	(15) with $C_{\max}$ = MaxActive-EP capacity, $C_{\min} = 0$; output rule (16)

TABLE 3. MaxActive Capacity (Gbps) Versus Distance

	Aligned		Diag. w/ adj.		Diag. no adj.	
d (m)	WF	EP	WF	EP	WF	EP
1	29421	29412	29421	29412	29421	29412
21	2013	2006	15.40	15.34	6.2×10^{-3}	6.2×10^{-3}
61	518.1	516.5	0.491	0.491	1.9×10^{-4}	1.9×10^{-4}
101	208.3	207.5	0.084	0.084	3.3×10^{-5}	3.3×10^{-5}

exceeds the reference at one or more points, so the size of the violation is a first-class selection criterion. The piecewise-constant single tree and plain gradient boosting overshoot by thousands of percent, because they cannot extrapolate the wide dynamic range, and a link budget dimensioned on such a prediction would be badly optimistic. GaussProc and ExtraTrees, by contrast, stay within a few percent. The D3QN capacity did not exceed the MaxActive-EP reference at any of the evaluated geometries, as expected for a policy that selects among the same SNR-ordered prefixes.

Table 5 breaks the out-of-fold median relative error down by scenario for the strongest models. For four of the five models, at least one misaligned scenario is harder than the aligned one; k-NN, for example, rises to 20.1% in the worst-SNR regime (misaligned, no adjustment). The Gaussian process is the exception and stays within 2% in all three scenarios. SVR-RBF and KernelRidge stay within about 7% everywhere, whereas ExtraTrees degrades in both misaligned scenarios. Stability across scenarios, and not merely a low aggregate error, is what qualifies a model as a robust predictor.

On the elevation and real-trace scenarios, fitting on all 60 samples, the strongest models reproduce the curves closely: XGBoost, GradBoost, and GaussProc reach median relative errors of 0.07%, 0.7%, and 2.8% over the elevation and real scenarios, with Huber regression next at 4.4%. The mobility errors come from an in-sample fit, which flatters models such as GradBoost that fail under cross-validation, so the ranking rests on the nested cross-validation rather than on the in-sample fit.

The D3QN, trained as a single-step contextual bandit at every trajectory point, reaches at least 99.7% of the MaxActive-EP capacity on all seven scenario variants. The mean capacity ratio is 99.9% for the aligned case and 100.0% for each of the six misaligned cases: diagonal, elevation, and real-trace mobility, each with and without beamwidth adjustment. The worst single operating point over all 93 evaluated geometries (33 in the main study plus 60 mobility points) is 99.7% of the reference, and no point exceeds the reference. The selected channel counts are not always identical to those of MaxActive; in the main study the counts differ by up to 30 channels (e.g., 497 versus 467 at 81 m in the aligned case). Near its maximum, the capacity is flat

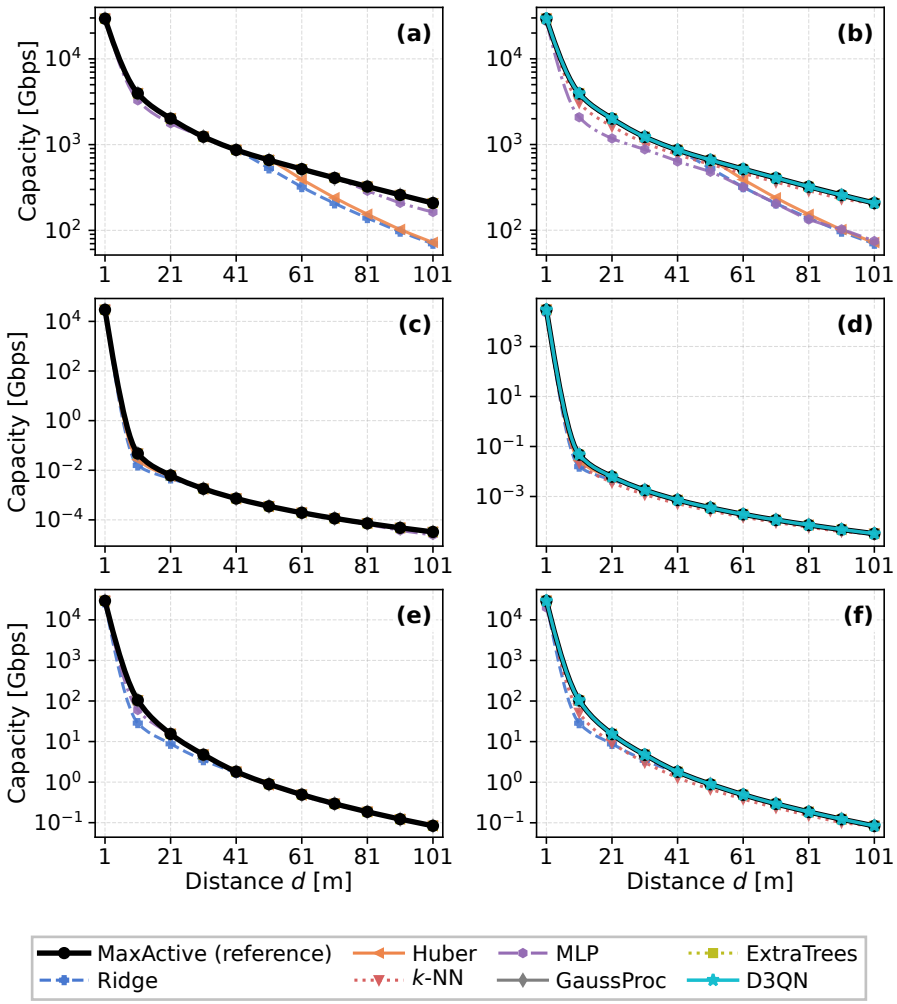


FIGURE 2. **Learned models versus MaxActive in the aligned and diagonal scenarios. Rows: (a), (b) aligned; (c), (d) misaligned diagonal mobility without beamwidth adjustment; (e), (f) misaligned diagonal mobility with beamwidth adjustment. Columns: WF target in (a), (c), (e) and EP target in (b), (d), (f); the D3QN, which uses EP, appears in the EP column. One regressor per family is shown; all eighteen are compared in Table 4. Regressor curves are models fit on all 33 samples, clipped at the MaxActive ceiling (13) for display only (a deployed regressor has no access to the ceiling), and PCHIP-smoothed with markers at the computed points.**

in the number of active channels, so neighboring prefixes deliver almost the same capacity. A policy operating at the same individual-channel granularity as MaxActive-EP thus returns a transmittable channel set of nearly reference capacity, under elevation and real-trace mobility as well. The ratio is bounded by construction, because the policy chooses among the same SNR-ordered prefixes. Training uses the reference capacity in the reward, and the reported decision is the better of the greedy action and the best of the 1600 actions evaluated during training (16), so the reported ratios characterize the complete training-plus-selection procedure. How often the greedy network output alone attains the ratios was not recorded.

The contrast between the regressors and the policy is the most transferable finding of the study. A regressor predicts a number and can exceed the physical bound. The policy predicts an allocation, and the capacity reported for the policy is the capacity that the chosen allocation actually delivers, so the policy stays at or below the MaxActive-EP reference (99.7–100%) with no clip anywhere in the pipeline. Where an allocation must be trusted without supervision, learning the decision is the safer target, subject to the per-context training that the policy currently requires. The study also has limitations that bound these claims. The datasets are small (33 and 60 points) and physically smooth, which favors smoothness-assuming models and restricts the validated regime to interpolation within the trained envelope. The learned models imitate a reference that is optimal only within its threshold-search family, so the models inherit that scope rather than approximating a globally optimal allocation. The regressors predict the capacity value rather than the channel set, so a system that needs the set must use the policy, and the policy is trained per context rather than as a single geometry-generalizing agent.

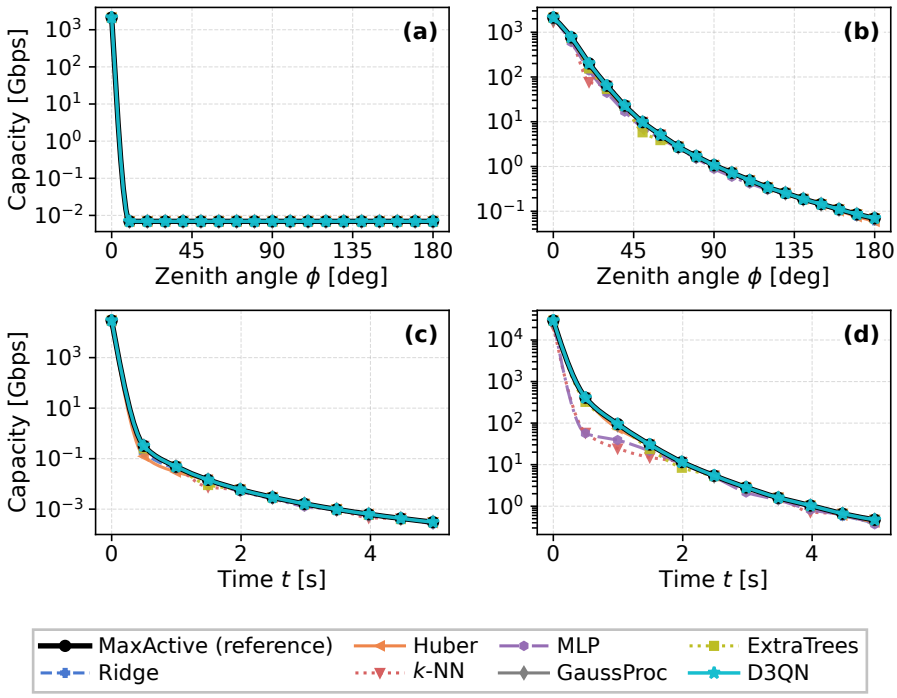


FIGURE 3. **Learned models versus MaxActive on the two additional mobility patterns (EP target): mobility over elevation (a) without and (b) with beamwidth adjustment, where ϕ is the elevation (zenith) angle of the Rx seen from the Tx; and real windy-hover traces (c) without and (d) with adjustment. Same model representatives as Fig. 2. WF panels are omitted because WF and EP coincide to within the line width. Regressor curves are in-sample fits on the 60 mobility samples, clipped at the ceiling for display only, and PCHIP-smoothed. The D3QN (cyan) lies on the MaxActive curve throughout.**

V. CONVERGENCE AND COMPLEXITY

A. ASYMPTOTIC COST

MaxActive has a per-step cost of $O(Q\,|\mathcal{F}|)$ and must be re-run whenever the geometry changes; the search needs no training but incurs its full cost at every time step. The supervised models move the cost offline. The entire nested-CV benchmark of 18 models over both targets completes in about 30 s on a CPU, dominated by the grid searches, and fitting the 18 deployable models on the full dataset takes 0.5 s. Afterwards, a prediction is a single forward, kernel, or neighbor evaluation. Table 6 summarizes the asymptotic training and prediction complexity of representative families (n samples, d features, T trees, W network weights, n_{sv} support vectors), together with their measured cost and cross-validated accuracy, and adds the MaxActive and D3QN references for context.

B. MEASURED EXECUTION TIME

Asymptotic orders alone do not establish a practical benefit, so every stage was measured on identical channel states, on a single core of an Intel Core i7-13620H, with the band discretized into $|\mathcal{F}| = 11\,700$ active channels per context. The measured values are averages over the eleven aligned contexts.

The reference costs 77 ms for the threshold sweep alone and 95 ms for a complete link update with power allocation iterated to convergence. On the three geometries where both variants were timed, adding the beamwidth search raises the update time from 72 ms to 91 ms, i.e., to $1.3\times$ the fixed-beam cost. The regressor path, in comparison, costs 0.84 ms to turn the channel state into the 13 features and 21–43 μs to evaluate a linear, kernel, or Gaussian-process model, which amounts to 0.9 ms end-to-end and an $88\times$ reduction in the per-update decision cost. The model evaluation alone is 1800–$3700\times$ faster than the search, but feature extraction dominates the online path, so the end-to-end gain saturates near two orders of magnitude, and feature extraction rather than inference is the target for further optimization. The tree ensembles are an exception: they need 3.0–12 ms per prediction, since hundreds of estimators must each be traversed, which cuts their advantage to 6–$20\times$ and makes the ensembles a poor per-update choice at the present dataset size despite their accuracy. The D3QN gives the fastest decision among the evaluated methods. The D3QN state is built from the SNR ranking that MaxActive computes anyway (0.55 ms, shared by both methods), after which a forward pass and $\arg\max$ take 0.05 ms, three orders of magnitude below the search, and the policy returns the channel set itself rather than a capacity estimate. The D3QN cost is paid offline: 0.11 s per context, or about 4 s for the 33 contexts of the main study. Training one context thus costs more than one threshold sweep (77 ms) and also needs the reference capacity of the context, so the per-context policy

TABLE 4. Nested Cross-Validated Accuracy and Physical-Ceiling Violations (EP Target, Ranked Best to Worst)

	Nested-CV generalization			Ceiling violations	
Model	RMSE $\pm$ std	R^2	Med. rel.	pts.	max
GaussProc	0.100 ± 0.23	0.991	1.9%	19	2.7%
ExtraTrees	0.237 ± 0.18	0.986	12.1%	1	3.7%
SVR-RBF	0.253 ± 0.22	0.982	7.8%	18	318%
MLP	0.254 ± 0.21	0.980	21.1%	20	226%
BayesianRidge	0.331 ± 0.14	0.976	42.5%	17	322%
k-NN	0.338 ± 0.29	0.959	9.0%	11	111%
XGBoost	0.342 ± 0.16	0.970	36.9%	14	38%
KernelRidge	0.356 ± 0.33	0.962	16.0%	17	223%
Lasso/ENet/Ridge	0.36–0.37	0.97	45–49%	17–19	232–261%
GradBoost	0.412 ± 0.21	0.957	38.4%	16	2993%
RF/Bag./AdaBoost	0.44–0.45	0.96	49–62%	9–11	97–246%
Huber	0.504 ± 0.37	0.930	48.4%	17	1102%
DecisionTree	0.561 ± 0.32	0.931	48.0%	3	3698%
LinearReg	3.281 ± 8.78	-7.98	55.8%	15	405%
D3QN (policy)	—	—	$\sim$0%	0	0%

RMSE and R^2: $\log_{10}$ target; Med. rel.: median relative error in linear Gbps; all from raw, unclipped out-of-fold predictions. "pts.": number of the 33 points at which the prediction exceeds the reference; "max": largest such excess, i.e., what (13) conceals. ENet = ElasticNet, RF = RandomForest, Bag. = Bagging. D3QN row: capacity of the selected channel set relative to MaxActive-EP (not a regression metric).

TABLE 5. Per-Scenario Median Relative Error (EP Target, Nested-CV Out-of-Fold Predictions)

		Misaligned (diagonal)	
Model	Aligned	No adjustment	With adjustment
GaussProc	2.0%	1.9%	0.8%
SVR-RBF	2.6%	5.3%	6.9%
KernelRidge	4.9%	6.0%	5.3%
k-NN	1.2%	20.1%	0.7%
ExtraTrees	2.7%	12.2%	24.6%

saves computation only when a trained context is revisited, and the online figure above applies to such contexts.

C. MEMORY FOOTPRINT AND AIRBORNE DEPLOYMENT

For a UAV, memory and predictability matter as much as speed. The deployable models are small: the regularized-linear models occupy 1.2–2.2 KB, SVR-RBF 4.6 KB, the Gaussian process 17.9 KB (its 33×33 kernel and training inputs), the MLP 70 KB, and the D3QN 21 561 parameters, i.e., 84 KB in single precision. Models of this size are compatible with the on-chip memory of microcontroller-class flight companions, and all are far smaller than the LBLRTM tables that the reference search itself must hold. Only the tree ensembles are heavy, with XGBoost at 522 KB and ExtraTrees at 1.4 MB, which, together with their millisecond-scale inference, makes the ensembles a poor fit here despite their accuracy. Three further properties favor deployment. The inference cost is constant and independent of the data, a fixed number of multiply-accumulates with no search, iteration, or early exit, so the decision has a hard worst-case latency that a threshold sweep of state-dependent length cannot offer. All training is offline, so the platform performs no gradient computation. Finally, the arithmetic could be compressed further: an 8-bit D3QN would occupy about 21 KB (not evaluated here), and the linear models reduce to a 13-element dot product. On these grounds, the Gaussian process is the better choice where accuracy dominates (18 KB, 43 μs), and the D3QN where the channel set is needed (84 KB, 0.05 ms, subject to per-context training). The tree ensembles are best reserved for offline or ground-station use. The reported sizes and latencies indicate feasibility within the memory and latency budgets of a flight companion. All timings, however, come from a laptop-class CPU, so absolute latencies on an embedded airborne processor will be larger. The ratio between search and learned model is expected to carry over approximately, since both run on the same processor, but the ratio has not been measured on embedded hardware, and a full airborne demonstration remains future work.

D. CONVERGENCE

For the supervised models, convergence is that of their standard solvers and is not a limiting factor; the cost lies in the offline grid search. For the D3QN, the single-step formulation removes bootstrapping variance and the credit-assignment horizon, which makes training well conditioned. With the budget of 20 epochs of 80 actions, the returned decision (16) reached 99.7–100% of the reference capacity in all four mobility patterns. Because (16) also considers the actions explored during training, the budget is a measured sufficient setting for the complete procedure, not a convergence result for the greedy network alone. Learning curves of the greedy action were not recorded and are left to future work. The coupled power-allocation and MaxActive loop inside the reference stops when the two channel sets agree and is capped at 30 iterations; the iteration counts of the loop were not recorded.

E. ACCURACY VERSUS COMPLEXITY

The results reveal a clear accuracy-versus-complexity trade-off, which is the central practical conclusion of the study. The most accurate model, the Gaussian process, has the highest asymptotic training cost ($O(n^3)$ time, $O(n^2)$ memory, and a prediction that requires the full training kernel). The next best models, SVR-RBF and kernel ridge regression, are likewise kernel based at $O(n^2$–$n^3)$, and the cheapest models ($O(nd^2)$ training, $O(d)$ prediction) are systematically biased ($\approx$ 45% median error). The accuracy ranking of Table 4 therefore roughly tracks the asymptotic cost ranking of Table 6: the last few percent of accuracy are bought at a super-linear price in the number of samples.

TABLE 6. Asymptotic and Measured Cost Versus Accuracy of Representative Models

	Asymptotic cost		Measured (single core, $n = 33$)			Nested-CV accuracy (EP)	
Model (family)	Training	Prediction	Train [ms]	Predict [ms]	Memory [KB]	R^2	Med. rel. err.
Ridge / Lasso (linear)	$O(nd^2)$	$O(d)$	0.7	0.023	1.2	0.97	45%
k-NN (instance-based)	$O(1)$ (store)	$O(nd)$	0.5	0.211	7.6	0.96	9%
DecisionTree (tree)	$O(nd \log n)$	$O(\text{depth})$	0.4	0.029	5.3	0.93	48%
XGBoost / ExtraTrees (ensemble)	$O(T\, nd \log n)$	$O(T$ depth$)$	76–103	0.32–11.7	522–1362	0.97–0.99	12–37%
MLP (neural)	$O(\text{it} \cdot nW)$	$O(W)$	49	0.031	70	0.98	21%
SVR-RBF (kernel)	$O(n^2 - n^3)$	$O(n_{sv} d)$	0.8	0.038	4.6	0.98	8%
GaussProc (kernel/prob.)	$O(n^3)$, mem $O(n^2)$	$O(n)$ mean	14	**0.043**	**17.9**	**0.99**	**1.9%**
MaxActive (reference)	— (online search)	$O(Q\|\mathcal{F}\|)$ / step	—	**76.8**	—	reference	—
D3QN (policy)	$O(E \cdot A)$ / context	$O(\text{forward pass})$	115/ctx.	0.05	84	$\approx$ ref.	$\sim$0%

Prediction times are per operating point and exclude the 0.84 ms feature extraction shared by all regressors; the MaxActive row is the threshold sweep alone, on the same channel states. Memory is the serialized model size; the D3QN size corresponds to 21 561 parameters in single precision. For the D3QN, E is the number of training epochs and A the number of actions evaluated per epoch.

The dataset size determines whether this trade-off matters in practice. At the present scale ($n \leq 60$), the asymptotic penalty is invisible in wall-clock terms. The Gaussian process trains in 14 ms and predicts in 43 μs, which is cheaper at inference than k-NN or any ensemble, so the most accurate model can be chosen without a practical penalty, and the Gaussian process is the model we recommend at the present scale. The time cost at the present scale comes from the number of estimators rather than the asymptotic class, which is why the tree ensembles are the slowest predictors in the table. As n grows toward the 10^4–10^6 samples that denser simulation grids would provide, the cubic training cost and quadratic memory of the kernel methods become prohibitive, while the ensembles amortize their per-tree overhead, and the balance shifts to XGBoost and ExtraTrees. Kernel methods are thus preferable while the dataset is small, and tree ensembles once the dataset is large.

VI. CONCLUSION

This paper studied spectrum allocation for THz UAV links, where molecular absorption, absorption noise, and mobility-induced beam misalignment make the choice of active channels and their powers decisive for capacity. Taking the MaxActive threshold search as the reference solution, we investigated two machine-learning alternatives that work from the same physical channel state: supervised regressors that predict the capacity the search achieves, and a D3QN contextual-bandit policy that learns the channel selection itself.

The results show that smoothness is the inductive bias that matters for the present problem. The capacity surface is smooth and wide-ranging, so kernel and Gaussian-process models track the reference closely, whereas piecewise-constant learners cannot extrapolate the surface and overshoot the physical bound by orders of magnitude. On datasets of the present size, the evaluation protocol also decides the ranking: a single split reorders the models and hides overfitting, which makes nested cross-validation a requirement rather than a refinement. Learning the decision proved safer than learning its value, because a policy that selects channels reports only capacities that a transmittable allocation actually delivers, whereas a value regressor can predict a rate the link cannot support.

In terms of cost, once trained, both learned branches lower the online decision cost by about two orders of magnitude or more relative to the search, and both fit in the memory of a small flight computer. For the regressors, feature extraction rather than inference now limits the speed-up. At the present scale, the Gaussian process is the preferred capacity predictor, and the D3QN is preferred where the channel set is needed. Only as the dataset grows by orders of magnitude does the super-linear cost of kernel methods favor tree ensembles. The D3QN branch is trained per operating context with the reference capacity in its reward, and the reported decision also draws on the actions explored in training, so the branch covers a pre-enumerated trajectory envelope rather than an arbitrary unseen geometry and pays off only when trained contexts recur. The regressors are validated as interpolators within the trained envelope, and all timings come from a laptop-class CPU. Future work will replace the per-context bandits with a single geometry-generalizing policy, evaluate the greedy policy without the training-time fallback, predict the channel set rather than only the capacity, validate on embedded hardware, and extend the dataset into the regime where the complexity trade-off binds.

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technical content, modelling choices, results, and conclusions are developed and verified by the authors.

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